

# At the End, Totò Always Scores

*Chance, Merit, and the Italian Summer That Chose Schillaci*

Carlo Vilches | June 2026

Notti magiche, inseguendo un gol.  
— “*Un'estate italiana*” (1990)

Six years before Salvatore Schillaci became the face of a World Cup, Giorgio Moroder drove into a Los Angeles recording studio with a problem in his Ferrari. The brakes needed work. The man who fixed them was Tom Whitlock, a mechanic who took the opportunity to mention that he also wrote songs.

This is the kind of detail that biographies preserve because it makes a life look scripted after the fact. A Ferrari arrives with bad brakes; the mechanic happens to be a lyricist; the owner happens to be one of the most successful producers in popular music. Moroder eventually brought Whitlock into the studio. When his usual collaborators were unavailable for *Top Gun*, the mechanic was asked to write.

Whitlock helped produce five songs for the film, including “Danger Zone” and “Take My Breath Away.” Moroder supplied the strange, suspended bass line; Whitlock began thinking through the lyric while driving home. The song was first offered to the Motels. Columbia suggested other singers, including Alison Moyet. It finally went to Berlin, a band divided by the gift: Terri Nunn understood that the song could take them around the world; John Crawford resented that their greatest hit had not been written or even played by the group. “Take My Breath Away” won the Academy Award. It also helped pull Berlin apart.

The song did not belong naturally to the mechanic, the band or perhaps even the film. It passed through all of them and made each look, retrospectively, as if it had been waiting for precisely that encounter.

*Top Gun* performed the same trick on Tom Cruise. He was not an accidental replacement—Jerry Bruckheimer and the filmmakers wanted him—but he still had to be convinced. They put him in a jet with the Blue Angels. His stomach gave out during the flight, and he accepted the role after landing. The movie that helped turn him into the most durable action star of his generation began by proving that his body could lose control before his will recovered it.

The coincidence matters because four years later Moroder and Whitlock were asked to write for another machine that manufactured heroes: the World Cup. Their English song was called “To Be Number One.” It said what an official sporting anthem was expected to say. Compete honestly. Reach the summit. Win.

It was competent, international and almost impossible to remember.

Moroder then brought the melody to Gianna Nannini and Edoardo Bennato. Nannini reportedly resisted at first; the assignment felt too commercial and too distant from her own music. She accepted, in part, because her father loved football. She and Bennato did not simply translate Whitlock's words. They changed the object of desire.

Whitlock had written a destination: number one. Nannini and Bennato wrote a memory: magical nights, a goal pursued beneath an Italian sky.

The difference became decisive because Italy did not win the tournament. The English lyric promised an outcome the team never delivered. The Italian lyric promised a summer that would survive its own defeat. That promise was fulfilled.

It was fulfilled by a player who was not supposed to carry it.

## **The summer and the body**

Everybody remembers Schillaci's eyes. They opened after each goal as if the scorer had arrived a fraction of a second after the ball and was as shocked as the rest of the country to find both of them inside the net.

Memory has been less fair to his hips.

Schillaci is often reduced to a fortunate poacher, a man repeatedly standing where the goalkeeper happened to leave the rebound. But the footage shows a more complete footballer: a low centre of gravity, a quick waist, sharp acceleration over a few metres and the ability to prepare a violent finish before a defender could reset his feet.

Against Uruguay, he did not merely receive good fortune. Aldo Serena returned the ball to him outside the penalty area; Schillaci turned through the small space available and struck upward with force. The shot rose violently and dropped beyond Fernando Álvarez. It looked improvised because the preparation was almost invisible. The metre did not exist until his body manufactured it.

Against Ireland, the mechanism was different. Roberto Donadoni drove a shot toward Packie Bonner, who could only parry it. Schillaci was already moving. Most players watched the strike; he ran toward its possible consequence.

Against Uruguay, he created the metre. Against Ireland, he predicted where the metre would appear.

Luck supplied the loose ball. It did not supply the run.

That distinction is the heart of the essay. Schillaci did not earn every circumstance that placed him at Italia 90. He had played only one season for Juventus and had almost no senior international history. He began the opening match against Austria on the bench. Italy was stuck at 0–0 when Azeglio Vicini sent him on. Four minutes later, he headed in the winner.

Chance opened the door. Schillaci still had to enter it.

Then he had to justify his presence again. He scored against Czechoslovakia, Uruguay, Ireland, Argentina and England. Six goals in seven matches; the Golden Boot; the Golden Ball; second place in the Ballon d'Or. He finished his entire international career with seven goals. Six belonged to that one summer.

This is why “at the end, Schillaci always scores” feels true even though his career disproves it. During the tournament, a run became a law. Afterward, the law disappeared.

Gary Lineker's famous description of football offered the opposite kind of inevitability: twenty-two men chase the ball and, at the end, the Germans win. Germany made preparation, repetition and institutional strength look like fate. Its victories seemed to precede the matches that produced them. The players moved, but the destination had already been decided.

Schillaci's destiny was assembled differently. Nothing about it appeared necessary beforehand: Vialli's poor form, Italy's difficulty against Austria, Vicini's glance toward the bench, the rebound from Bonner, the ball returned by Serena. Each was a small contingency. Yet once Totò scored six times, memory edited those accidents into a path.

Germany made structure look like destiny. Schillaci made opportunity look predestined—but only after earning it.

## **Do we deserve what happens to us?**

This question produced a minor philosophical argument on the French-speaking internet: do successful people deserve their success, or is success mainly the result of chance? One side emphasized the accident—the family, network, timing and visibility that no worker fully controls. The other insisted on the response: opportunities do not exploit themselves; preparation and effort alter the probability of success.

Schillaci makes the dispute harder because both positions are visibly present in the same body.

The philosopher Thomas Nagel called this problem *moral luck*. We normally want praise and blame to depend on what a person controls. Yet our judgments constantly depend on circumstances and outcomes beyond that control. Nagel separated several forms of luck: the situations in which we happen to act, the character and abilities we did not wholly choose, the causal history behind our decisions, and the eventual result of what we do.

Schillaci did not choose the historical placement of the tournament, the physical condition of the other strikers or the direction of every rebound. He also did not choose, in any complete sense, the body with which he responded: the low centre of gravity, the explosive first steps, the temperament that made him attack the ball rather than wait for certainty.

But none of that makes him a spectator to his own success.

The opportunity was not a reward for merit because it arrived before the demonstration. The merit appeared in the response. He did not deserve in advance that Vicini choose him against Austria. After six goals, he deserved to be remembered as the player of the tournament.

Bernard Williams approached the same problem from another direction. In his essay on moral luck, he imagined an artist loosely based on Gauguin who abandons ordinary obligations in order to create. If the work becomes great, the later achievement seems to justify the earlier decision; if it fails, the same decision appears selfish or absurd. The outcome travels backward and changes the meaning of the act that preceded it.

Football does this every week. If Schillaci misses against Austria, Vicini looks desperate. Because he scores, the substitution becomes intuition. After six goals, even the original call-up begins to look prophetic.

The goal does not only change the score. It travels backward and changes the story of how the scorer arrived.

This is not proof that destiny exists. It is evidence that narration does. Human beings are poor at leaving contingency unresolved. Once we know the ending, we recruit every earlier accident into its service. Nassim Nicholas Taleb calls a related habit being fooled by randomness: winners are treated as if the qualities visible after success had guaranteed the success before it happened. Survivors acquire biographies; equally prepared failures disappear from the sample.

Totò's six goals were not random. The belief that they had always been waiting for him was.

Spinoza supplies a useful way out of the sterile choice between total freedom and total determination. Freedom, in this view, does not mean floating outside causes. It means increasing our ability to act through an understanding—never complete—of what moves us and what surrounds us.

Schillaci cannot command Bonner to release the ball. He can understand what a hard shot may produce and begin the run before certainty arrives. His freedom exists inside the causes, not beyond them.

He did not choose the door. He recognized it was open.

## **The narrow ladders**

The language of merit becomes more dangerous when it leaves football.

A striker can reasonably deserve praise for a turn, a run and a finish. It does not follow that economic winners deserve every advantage produced by their success. John Rawls argued that even our natural abilities belong partly to a “natural lottery”: nobody earns the family, society or initial distribution of talents into which they are born. Michael Sandel later described the pride of winners who forget this dependence as *meritocratic*

*hubris*. If success is interpreted as proof of virtue, failure becomes evidence of personal deficiency.

Thomas Piketty's work on inherited wealth places an economic structure beneath that moral language. Wealth reproduces itself across generations. Property, education, social networks and the ability to survive failure are transmitted before effort begins. The heir starts several metres ahead and may later describe the finishing order as a measurement of character.

The self-made man is usually a gifted editor of his own footnotes.

Popular music and sport have long supplied the West with its favourite rebuttal. The boy from the poor neighbourhood becomes a football hero. The mechanic who repairs a Ferrari writes an Oscar-winning song. A singer is discovered in a bar. These stories are not false. Their power comes from being true.

But a ladder can be real and still be too narrow for everyone who deserves to climb it.

For every Schillaci, there were thousands of boys with fast hips, hunger and discipline who never met the scout, survived the injury or reached the bench on the correct night. For every Whitlock, there were mechanics with notebooks who never repaired the right Ferrari. The exception proves that movement is possible. It does not prove that opportunity is fairly distributed.

This is why music and football can be both genuine ladders and excellent advertisements for unequal societies. Their rare ascents allow inherited structures to present themselves as open competitions. The successful player may have worked harder than almost anyone. That still does not mean everyone began from the same line.

Chance, merit and justice are three different questions:

Who received the opportunity?

What did that person do with it?

How much of the reward should be treated as exclusively theirs?

Schillaci answers the second question magnificently. His story cannot settle the other two.

## **From an Italian summer to the global product**

The history of World Cup songs followed its own movement from national memory toward global entertainment.

Italia 90 offered a striking contradiction. "Un'estate italiana" promised magical nights and an expanding horizon. The football itself was cautious, interrupted and historically low-scoring: 2.21 goals per match, still the lowest average in World Cup history. The Etrusco Unico ball carried lions inspired by ancient Italy and new polyurethane technology; the stadiums offered monumental television images; many teams responded by closing space.

The song promised summer. The tournament often delivered winter.

Schillaci was the brief moment when the advertisement became true.

Four years later, the United States offered “Gloryland,” built from the traditional spiritual “Glory, Glory (Lay My Burden Down)” and performed in its vocal form by Daryl Hall and Sounds of Blackness. Yet for many viewers, especially through television packages, the instrumental version—the saxophone, the solemn lift, the opening sequence—proved more durable than the lyric. Italia 90 had produced a song that became autobiography. USA 94 often sounded like presentation music.

Then came France 98. FIFA approached Ricky Martin after the international success of “María.” “La Copa de la Vida,” written by Luis Gómez Escolar, Desmond Child and Draco Rosa, changed the industrial function of the World Cup song. It was not only an anthem attached to a host nation. It was a global pop vehicle: rhythm, command, choreography, video and a star capable of carrying the tournament outside the stadium. Martin performed it before the 1998 final and then at the 1999 Grammys, a performance widely associated with the Latin-pop explosion in the United States.

In 1990, the song represented the country. In 1998, the World Cup and the singer exported each other.

By 2010, the machine had become planetary. Shakira, a Colombian star, performed the official song of the first African World Cup with the South African band Freshlyground. “Waka Waka” drew its famous refrain from “Zangalewa,” popularized in 1986 by Golden Sounds, a Cameroonian group whose members came from the presidential guard. That music had already travelled through Africa and the Caribbean into Colombia before returning to an African World Cup as global pop.

The route was not Africa to Shakira. It was Africa to Latin America to the world and back to Africa, with Sony and FIFA collecting the passports.

The song’s success was immense; so was the controversy over appropriation and FIFA’s choice of a non-South-African superstar. A settlement recognized the Cameroonian authors. The episode exposed what World Cup music had become: not simply a local culture presented globally, but a global industry assembling recognisable fragments of locality.

This entire path is already present in miniature inside “Un’estate italiana.” An Italian producer working in Los Angeles hires an American mechanic-lyricist; an English song is rewritten by two Italian rock stars; the rewritten version outlives the official message; a Sicilian substitute turns it into national memory.

The song was global before globalization learned to dance.

## **The part nobody deserves**

Salvatore Schillaci died in Palermo on 18 September 2024, aged fifty-nine, after an illness. This is where the language of merit finally breaks.

We want lives to possess a moral accounting. Work should receive opportunity; courage should receive reward; a man who gives joy should receive time. The world does not accept those terms.

Schillaci did not deserve the accidents that opened the door against Austria. They were not payment for work already completed. He deserved what he did after the door opened: the header, the turn, the anticipation, the repeated ability to arrive while an entire country held its breath.

He did not deserve to leave the world at fifty-nine.

And we did nothing to deserve the memory he left us.

This is not an argument against effort. It is an argument against treating destiny as a fair distribution. Some gifts arrive before merit. Some losses arrive without justice. Between them, a person acts.

Lineker's Germans lived in a deterministic joke. Everyone ran, but history already knew the ending. Schillaci belonged to a less orderly universe. A mechanic repaired a Ferrari. A producer remembered him. A band recorded a song it did not write. An Italian singer accepted a commercial assignment for her father. A lyric about victory became a lyric about memory. A substitute entered against Austria.

Nothing had to happen. Then Totò scored.

And because he scored again, and again, and again, contingency began to look like fate.

At the end, the Germans always win. At the end, Schillaci always scores. One sentence describes a system so repeatable that it resembles destiny. The other describes a summer so unrepeatable that memory had to invent destiny to explain it.

The summer ended. The law was repealed.

The memory was not.

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